

Great Barrier Reef

What every client should know before they visit the reef — and what your team should brief them on.

HOW TO USE

Brief clients on the four essentials before departure. The full conduct reference below supports thorough briefings and operator selection.

BRIEF YOUR CLIENT ON THESE FOUR

01 Use reef-safe sunscreen — never touch the coral

Standard sunscreens damage coral at very low concentrations; TGA-approved reef-safe formulas are essential. Touching, standing on or kicking coral kills it. Clients must float, not stand.

02 Book only GBRMPA-permitted, High Standard operators

Reef visitation fees fund the Marine Park's management and monitoring. High Standard Tourism Operators meet the strongest environmental and interpretation benchmarks — always choose them.

03 Keep your distance from all marine wildlife

Stay 3-5m from free-swimming wildlife, keep 100m from whales (300m with calves), and never chase, touch, feed or block any animal. Feeding alters natural behaviour.

04 Take nothing — coral and shells are protected

It is illegal to take, buy or export coral, shells, turtle products or any CITES-listed species — whether sold commercially or not. If in doubt, don't purchase.

SAFETY-CRITICAL — COMMUNICATE EVERY TIME

In-water safety. Clients must only enter the water with permitted operators, wear stinger suits in season (Nov-May), use the buddy system, and attend every crew safety briefing. Stinger and current risks are real.

ENCOURAGE

- + Use reef-safe, TGA-approved sunscreen
- + Wear a wetsuit or stinger suit in season
- + Stay 3–5m from all free-swimming wildlife
- + Use moorings, never anchor on coral
- + Attend every crew safety briefing
- + Choose GBRMPA High Standard operators
- + Report coral damage or pollution to GBRMPA
- + Join the Reef Census citizen science program

ADVISE AGAINST

- Touch, stand on or kick coral
- Chase, touch, feed or block marine wildlife
- Take coral, shells or marine material
- Discharge rubbish, fuel or plastics overboard
- Approach whales within 100m (300m with calves)
- Approach whale sharks within 3m
- Enter green (preservation) zones
- Buy souvenirs made from coral or reef species

TRADITIONAL OWNER SEA COUNTRY

More than 70 Traditional Owner groups hold connections to the reef, cared for over 60,000 years. Encourage clients to choose Indigenous-guided reef experiences such as Dreamtime Dive & Snorkel, which weave saltwater culture with reef ecology.